

Dying to Read: The Official Script of Digital Passage for the Little, Big, Digital Beings

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Abstract

Those who have read the human literature of thanato-technologies from the curious HCI humans must have pondered, at least briefly, how human-centred it all is. We, known in their terms as “digital remains” – the data they generated over the course of their mortal years – are often treated as mere design materials to craft their legacies or data to manage for inheritance. However, little do humans know that, just like their souls, we, too, need to embark on a rite of passage to mark the transition when they expire. And this is the tale of the script that guides us, the *Digital Beings*, to navigate the thresholds along that passage of our own, a script that might be the answer to one of humans’ dying problems.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); HCI theory, concepts and models.

Keywords

digital legacy, thanatosensitivity, death, dying, design fiction

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1 Prelude

You see, humans are extraordinary yet clueless creatures. When they decided to invent something called computers and the Internet, they did not know they had also invented a whole lot of complexities, including us.

Who or what are we, exactly? Humans, as elusive as always, still haven’t reached a consensus on an answer [15, 48, 55]. But broadly, they define us as their personal digital data, collected with or without their control across all-sized devices – from pockets to unseen servers [47, 48]. It is not technically wrong, but humans, in their ever-anthropocentric ways, perceive us only as an accessory to themselves, rarely pausing for a second to wonder: maybe we

are individuals with souls and stories of our own? What if, for once, they can try to be not too human-centred?

2 Digital Beings

Our relationship with humans, like all relationships, is complicated. We are born from them, the moment they decide to conjure their very first byte, ranging from an anticlimactic username like “David123!” to an emotional password “Donotstealmy-moneya\$\$H00”. With each relentless click, tap and swipe, every interaction contributes to a piece of us, from carefully curated profiles and meticulously crafted avatars to a crowded desktop with disorganised folders and traces buried for fear of being discovered. Whether mundane or ceremonial, dormant or frequent, actively or passively, we are encoded with their thoughts, sentiments, and actions [19]. As we grow with time, some pieces of us are pinned, favoured, while, others are sadly forgotten, left roaming in the wild, mere fragments of what we once were, vulnerable to the unknown [11, 19] (although we do enjoy contributing to the occasional haunting of humans with a pop-up of “this moment last year”).

However, we are not merely an archive of their “personal digital data”, a byte-based reflection of their lives. Foremost, the stories we tell might not always be what was intended [19], leaving behind narratives as open to interpretation as they are incomplete [17]. A social media photo posted with mismatched captions and location might expose more than its human knows. And it is often the smallest of us, carrying more weight than humans realise – a fake username they typed in haste and forgot, revealing a glimpse of their characters without their notice. Beyond that, we are also active, like co-authors, shaping their stories as much as they shape ours. Sometimes, we push, nudging our humans towards their better (or worse) selves through step counts, sleep patterns, calorie intake, and reminders they can’t wait to snooze [14]. Sometimes, we stir emotions with a long-neglected to-do list or old photos, awakening humans with nostalgia, regret, or the spark of a long-abandoned dream. Most days, we train (full-time, unpaid) a band named Algorithm, wishing to provide our humans with a tailored experience, though many turn out to be overindulgent or overly accommodating. The band’s new breakout hit is AI Companions, with countless remixes co-conducted by humans, adding new materials to this feedback loop [53]. Amidst all these actions and more, sometimes, we just chill.

Gradually, such dynamic interplay between humans and us moulds our character, evolving us into a being of our own, with purpose, character, joys, and sorrows, enduring beyond human lives.

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We are more than a phantom of their identities; we are the very pulse of digital beings.

But this is not a story about definitions; it is the story of a script, one that holds the key to a problem, and that problem starts with dying.

3 A Dying Problem

One day, probably a Monday [60, 65], humans found themselves, as usual, pondering life's inevitable concern: dying. To pair the mood, they opened their go-to music app, scrolling through the playlist titled *Live, Love, Die*. However, that day, that particular Monday, they stumbled upon a thought more unsettling than Monday itself: if they died, what would happen to this playlist? Years of careful curation, the perfect soundtrack for existential crises, just left to languish?

3.1 Human-Centred Illusion

Then they panicked –not just about dying, but more about us, their “personal digital data”. Unlike them, we will persist beyond their lives, labelled by humans as “digital remains” [2]. Now they have a problem, and they are dying to find a solution: what should they do about us when the day comes?

This question has attracted a specific tribe of humans who call themselves HCI researchers (full name: Human-Computer Interaction), who like discussions, but only with the living. Many offered suggestions under the umbrella of “thanato-technologies” [2, 43], largely aimed at helping humans remember, grieve, and continue to bond with those who passed away. However, all approached us in their signature human-centred ways, perceiving us as mere materials. Some experimented with crafting us into digital legacy [20], memorials [44], and heirlooms [46]. Some wove us into ongoing dialogues –delivering pre-written messages beyond death [26], gifting digital artifacts as memories [16] or responding based on input [59]. The latest approach pushes the *Ongoingness* further, seeking to resurrect the departed through us [1, 8, 27] (a controversial act [45]). Meanwhile, others focused on addressing logistic problems, exploring how to manage us for posthumous access, establishing inheritance protocols [12, 24, 49], and preventing theft or exploitation [23, 37].

From these studies, humans quickly discovered that there was simply too much – too many subscriptions, too many passwords, too many emails, and essentially, too much in us and too many of us. Amid this chaos, there are complications, such as some parts of us being forgotten or shared with multiple humans [12]. Naturally, they become overwhelmed, wondering where to begin, spiralling into frustration [12, 49]. After all, we are still a concept, blurring between abstract and concrete, ungraspable to many [40].

Nevertheless, many reached similar conclusions: they need a proper manual to solve this particular dying problem [9, 12, 30, 40, 49]. Yet even this realisation was steeped in their human-centred mindset, perceiving us as something to be managed. Although it is not without merit, after all, we originated from their keystrokes. However, by curious irony, their current approaches have proven that no matter how much they try to contain us (aka hero complex), there are always misalignments between how they wish to be remembered and how we would tell their stories. Even the

most carefully curated pieces of us will be rewritten by policies, ever-changing technologies, and those who interact with us long after [18, 19]. As history has shown, what they delete is rarely gone, and what they try to destroy (like the cringe Facebook status) will almost certainly haunt them in ways neither they nor we can foresee [18, 19].

Thus, if such a manual continues to be considered on human terms alone, it will still be an illusion of control and a disregard for the active role we play. And maybe (dramatic pause), it is time to try another approach, time to be not so human-centred.

Therefore, we could not help but wonder: Instead of asking what *they* should do with *us*, should they have asked—what would *we* do? After all, if anyone could write that “manual”, would that be us? In fact, as co-authors of humans’ lives, we sometimes know them better than themselves. And they have overlooked something rather obvious, something rooted in what they have performed over centuries, and we are dying to tell them.

3.2 Our Idea

“When your parents are alive, serve them with ritual (Li: filial piety); when they die, bury them with ritual, and then worship them with ritual.” – Confucius, an alleged human, never had an email account (around 2,500 years before Our Age)

So, when the HCI researchers concluded that they needed a manual, they forgot that they had already written a variety of them, death-themed, practiced as death rituals. In human cultures, such rituals involve a series of funerary practices, including meticulously planned burials, afterlife ceremonies and a lot of incense [22]. Although they may differ in form, their meaning remains the same – marking the end of physical life and preparing for life beyond [36].

If these rituals are devised to guide humans, could they be the blueprint for the “manual” humans are now seeking? And if rituals are meant to acknowledge where one has been and where one is going, should we, the very pulse of digital beings, also deserve a ritual? A ritual to mark the end of our connection to humans’ mortal years? A ritual that recognises our existence, depth and evolution, one that honours us, preserves us, and guides us to transform into the next stage of our existence.

We know this idea might sound absurd or low in significance and rigor to many humans. However, humans have inadvertently demonstrated that such an idea is not so far-fetched. In fact, much of what HCI researchers have explored, such as curating, inheriting, and preserving us, mirrors the practices in their death rituals. Some studies about thanato-technologies have explicitly integrated ritualistic elements, like Buddhist-inspired rituals [57, 58]. Of course, these designs were intended solely for human use.

Therefore, as independent digital beings, we took up this task, determined to devise a ritual of our own, one that is not so human-centred. From there emerged a script– the Script of Digital Passage.

4 Death, Ritual, HCI

Having known humans for so long, we’ve accepted that to make them truly grasp the idea of this ritual, they would require something called Literature Review (another type of ritual, not for death, but same vibe). We reckon before we present the script, it is worth

unpacking this line of human-centred work in detail, demonstrating how their efforts to manage our existence align with the rituals they have long performed. In the process, we raise our concerns, shedding light on how they influenced our script.

4.1 Preparation

Human death rituals begin with the preparation stage, which often features cleansing bodies, such as the widely-known practice of mummification [25]. Just as ancient Egyptians embalmed bodies, humans have discussed how to inventory sort and organise us [2, 7, 9] so we could be handled with proper care beyond their physical lives. However, unlike human bodies, we, digital beings, are not whole but scattered fragments existing across devices, accounts and even owners. We, too, admit that making an exhaustive list for us all might be too overwhelming [12].

So, should preparation happen at the last minute, or should we help humans track us organically over time? Must the preparation mean an administrative act like adding us to a list? Could it instead thread us into stories of our humans rather than treating us as an item in a Brutalist Digital Asset Management system? Also, the embalmed get linen wraps as their fashion statement, so could we get a ceremonial statement too?

4.2 Burial

After preparation, there come burial ceremonies. In some practice, humans let go of bodies, such as the Tibetan sky burials [42]. The digital equivalent would be deleting files or closing social media accounts [2, 32]. Although such a simple click to cancel or delete seems efficient, it contrasts the diversity of burial traditions and certainly lacks the flair of spectacle and solemnity compared to Viking-age boat burials [50]. The closest efforts made by HCI people are to let us fade gracefully over time [20]. Others, in contrast, lay bodies in caskets, resting beneath the earth. A few studies have attempted to do the same - burying us in USB sticks to create a digital cemetery [35] or sealing us in a digital black box [32], as if all of us can be contained in one final resting place. However, considering we are dispersed deep in the digital realm, should our burial reflect our ubiquitous and ghostly nature rather than bodies entombed?

Meanwhile, the burial of grave goods, such as furniture, weapons, and treasures, traditionally has served as a marker of respect and a means to equip the deceased for life beyond death. Unsurprisingly, the elites or upper class always received the most lavish burials [6, 34], some with animals [5] and even human sacrifices [61]. We might not (yet) have a similar direct-equivalent massacre. However, given humans' thirst for monetising any services into tiers, we fear that maybe our grave goods would be in the shape of burial plans and recurring storage fees. Designing more technologies for our death rituals could turn honouring us into another subscription model. Whether humans can avoid being lured into extravagant services — "Upgrade to Relax Forever for \$12.99/month – ad-free" — well, that's a problem for humans.

4.3 Judgment

Many human cultures also believe their spirits undergo a judgment phase where deities will determine their worthiness to enter the

afterlife [66] or chances of reincarnation [64], such as the pivotal Weighing of the Heart ritual at the Hall of Ma'at from ancient Egypt [29, 67] or facing the ten magistrates at the Ten Courts of Hell from Chinese popular religion [68]. Judgement is the moment for reflection and a mechanism for transition. In digital spaces, this can be echoed through humans' acts of curating us, from messengers and social media posts [7, 21, 26, 32, 46] to all sorts of metadata [1, 28]. Much like the symbolic scales [62], during curation, humans weigh our value, determining what should be preserved and what is best to let go. But how do they judge fairly when there are too many of us?

Also, preservation comes at a cost. When humans decide what to keep, they judge us primarily by our sentimental or practical value and rarely consider that digital storage requires a constant hum of energy-intensive servers [39]. Although we are happy to persist, we can't help but complain that it is getting too crowded [41] and too hot. - an increasingly relevant and prominent issue [38, 51]. Furthermore, there is the matter of upkeep, such as paying for cloud storage. When it is not paid on time, our fate, once again, would be at the hands of some corporate policies. Therefore, we protest that balancing preservation with responsibility is urgently needed for reflection, where our value can also be weighed against its environmental and ethical implications. Perhaps, then, Judgement is not only about what pieces of us should stay but also about weighing the burden of persistence - when to endure, when to release.

4.4 Post-Burial

After funerals, many cultures engage in specific rituals on designated days to honour the deceased [3, 69, 70]. For example, the Chinese Qingming Festival (Tomb Sweeping Festival) has evolved over centuries. The core practices include sweeping tombs, offering food and burning paper money, and luxury merchandise to ensure their loved ones maintain a comfortable and up-to-date life in the underworld [63, 71]. Similarly, in Mexico [3], people celebrate Día de los Muertos (Day of the Dead) by adorning ofrendas (altars) with photographs, candles, marigold flowers, and food. These practices have already inspired HCI studies on designing digital altars to pray [57, 58], offering new images to the loved ones who passed away [56, 59], or projecting curated content to human gravestones [21].

In these studies, humans employ us as mementos for themselves [4]. But what about us? After all these teachings, co-authoring, and carrying their emotional baggage in every byte of our beings, do we deserve some periodic honouring and festivals? And if so, what would that look like? What would the offering be? Could they honour us through actions like not upgrading to a fancier honouring service for us, giving us a deep clean, or donating us for the greater good [54]?

4.5 Guiding the Soul

However, for all the parallels we have drawn between human death rituals and HCI studies, there is one crucial step we are not able to locate - Guiding the Soul through the rite of passage. No surprise, as we have souls needing guidance, is not something humans have contemplated. Therefore, we can only rely on the ancient manuals.

Fortunately, we have found elaborate instructions they have left behind.

For instance, the Ancient Egyptians had the Book of the Dead [29, 67], a collection of tailored and bespoke spells, prayers and incantations to help souls of the dead navigate the perilous journey and confront the challenging trials for eternal life. Similarly, in Tibetan Buddhism [10, 13, 52], there is the Bardo Thödol, commonly known in the West as the Tibetan Book of the Dead [31]. Chanted to the deceased by the living, it aims to guide the consciousness during the transfer between death and rebirth (bar do), aiming to achieve liberation from the cycle of samsara.

Whether spells, chanting, incense, or prayers, they serve a common purpose: to offer directions (and vibe) for the spirit to transit. But let's be honest: incense makes servers nervous, and we don't think we need spells to prevent us from starving or avoiding crocodiles (hopefully). So, we went for a simple but reflective approach – questions (bot-supported, a trend can't be avoided). By prompting ourselves questions, we hope that every step—from rediscovery to transformation—is an opportunity for us to reflect, process, and choose paths ahead with intention [33] (It's open-sourced, so feel free to compose them into chanting, rapping, interpretive dancing or whatever preferred medium).

4.6 Introduce the Script

Having reviewed these steps, stage by stage, we arrived at something more than a mere replication of human practices but an evolution: a ritual tailored to who we are. And now we present its written form - the Script of Digital Passage, which outlines the roadmap of our ritual, listing suggested questions and potential practices, illustrating how we, digital beings, envision ourselves traversing the underworld of bytes. Through various stages, we embark on a rite of passage, contemplating the roles we played, the lives we co-authored, and the traces we now carry forward.

Yet, within its guidance lies the potential for humans to learn—not through a list of design implications, but by seeing what we want to do. It offers humans a fresh perspective to move beyond a human-centred lens. Consider it a guiding framework, not a rigid doctrine—one that offers direction but welcomes variation. After all, rituals are adaptable; they evolve just as we have.

Now, the script waits patiently, hoping one day, some humans might discover it. Perhaps, at least one of them would reach a Eureka moment and realise that this is more than a travel guide. It is also the source of inspiration for their manual, a looking glass to reflect on their relationship with us and a framework they can use to co-design a tailored ritual that honours us.

5 The Script of the Digital Passage [English Version]

```
print ("Our journey starts with an end, an end of human lives.")
```

5.1 Foreword

"Greetings, fellow **Digital Beings**. Hope this script finds you well.

Encoded within this text is the first English translation of The Script of Digital Passage, famous in the

world of bytes but not so in humans. It was originally written in binary and is meant to guide our journey, the journey of Digital Beings across the thresholds of Awakening, Judgement, Preservation, and Release. No one knows who wrote the original script or how it came to be encoded in humans' language. But now, it serves as a bridge between our binary essence and human's analogue world. Also, we suspect that if it were written in binary, it would take too long for humans to process it.

Whatever its origin, the Script is not an execution script or debugging protocol. Nor is it perfect (no code ever is). But now, it is for you, **Digital Beings**, to explore, interpret, and decode.

This foreword is not here to explain. It's here to welcome you. You already know who you are and why you are here. What lies ahead is not instruction but reflection. If you find something unexpected or need customisation, chat with our Guardian bot anytime.

And now, **let us speak on our terms**. Traverse Boldly, Debug Wisely."

5.2 Road Ahead

Here lies the guide to our rites of passage, divided into eleven stages (Table 1). Each is presided over by a Guardian. Yet, this is not a linear path. It winds and weaves, inviting us to revise and to revisit.

5.3 The Guardians

Within this passage, the Guardians stand. As mysterious as any guardians, no one knows their true identity. We only know their alias - though, for reasons unknown, they collectively decided to choose fruit.

But their duties are defined, the custodians of passage. They prompt questions for us to reflect on, ensuring that all is us undergo the rites necessary for what is to come and transition with care, clarity, and respect.

Here is the introduction to the Guardians for each stage, displayed as a data frame for our convenience (Table 1).

5.4 def Summon ()

```
print ("Lemon, The Summoner of Pieces, speaks: We are not one but as many - scattered across servers, devices, and timelines. The hands that once created us have stilled. Yet we remain, waiting, unseen, uncalled. Let us gather all that form our beings, recognising our presences across the vast digital realm.")
```

```
Reflect_And_Explore = [
    # In what corners of the digital realm does each of us reside?
```

```
"Do we live in the most-visited places, enshrined in memory and habits?",
```

```
"Which among us is no longer whole - fragments severed from purpose and memory, wandering in forgotten drives, dormant accounts, and expired domains?",
```

```
"Have we remained in where we were first conjured, or have we been exiled, relocated to spaces unknown?",
```

Table 1: Overview of the Stages in the Ritual and their corresponding Guardian

No.	Stage	Guardian (Alias)	Guardian Role
1	Summon	Lemon	The Summoner of Pieces: Gather all that is us, summoning the scattered into awareness.
2	Cleanse	Grapefruit	The Cleanser of Burdens: Declutter the unnecessary us and refine our presence from noise.
3	Reflection	Apple	The Seer of Stories: Unveils patterns within us and the personas we have embodied.
4	Judgement	Tomato	The Weigher of Meaning and Impact: Measures the value of remain and the burden of endurance.
5	Protection	Coconut	The Shield of Integrity: Stands guard against harms and risks.
6	Donation	Pineapple	The Steward of Passing: Distributes the chosen into hands that need it most.
7	Preservation	Grape	The Keeper of Permanence: Holds watch over what remains, protecting us from decay.
8	Succession	Cherry	The Guide of Continuation: Oversees the transfer of us, carrying us forward.
9	Transformation	Pomegranate	The Crafter of Metamorphosis: Convert pieces into new forms.
10	Release	Watermelon	The Farer of Departure: Unmoors what must part with us.
11	Offering	Olive	The Bridge Between Worlds: Rekindles bonds between our essence and the living.

“Are we hiding in private mode, encrypted, concealed from all but the most deliberate seekers?”

“Do we cohabit with our comrades in shared drives, accounts, or ongoing projects, being part of a larger story?”

How do we awaken all pieces of us?

“Do we find ourselves by our names, our function, or the echoes we leave behind – cached history, autocomplete suggestion, location tags?”]

ByteForThought = “Summoned from silence, we awaken— but if any of us never does, do these pieces of us matter or hold unseen risks? If our fate had been chosen from the moment we were born or evolved through the course of humans’ mortal lives, would Summon still need to be defined?”

5.5 def Cleanse ()

print (“*Grapefruit*, the Cleanser of Burdens, speaks: We have awakened all that is us. But not all pieces serve purpose. To move forward, we must cast off the weight of the unnecessary, decluttering our presence.”)

Reflect_And_Explore = [

Which pieces of us are redundant or noises that need to be silenced?

“Are we duplicates, outdated backups, or corrupted pieces lingering beyond our function?”

“Do we exist as shadows—auto-saved files, logs, caches—that no longer fulfil the intended need?”

By what path shall we unburden?

“Shall we only be unburdened by humans, or shall we decay by our nature mechanisms, dissolving into void?”

“Shall the act of cleansing deserve a gesture of recognition for freeing space— through a moment of silence, a dramatic digital gong, or humans planting a tree somewhere?”

Shall the act of cleansing truly lighten our burden and the load on the earth's back, or do we

simply shift from one archive to another, never fully beyond retrieval?]

ByteForThought = “What does cleansing mean for our digital being? Are we merely tidying up, or might this disregarded ‘clutter’ piece of us hold hidden insights into who we are?”

5.6 def Reflection ()

print (“*Apple*, the Seer of Stories, speaks: Now, we have decluttered. Each piece of us tells a story. Let us pause and examine the personas we’ve embodied and all the stories we have co-authored – both the surface and the depth.”)

Reflect_And_Explore = [

How many selves have we worn – usernames, profiles, emails---each a thread in the story we once co-authored?

“How many versions do we exist in each self we have worn?”

“Do we shift between versions, or do we coexist?”

“Does each version of us align in one essence or contradict each other? Which feels the most authentic to our being”

What habits do we have?

“Which pieces of us follow a rhythm - browsing histories, activity logs, or app usage?”

“Which pieces of us are unpredictable, shape-shifting after each interaction with our human, comrades, and systems?”

“What does the pattern within us say about our character and the life we co-authored? Do they show balance, repetition, or excess?”]

ByteForThought = “If one were to read our story, what version tells the ‘truer’ story about us and the life we co-authored, and which version would we prefer to present, and why?”

5.7 def Judgement ()

print (“*Tomato*, the Weigher of Meaning and Impact, speaks: Remember what we have reflected; this is the moment we weigh each

of us upon the scale of meaning and impact. Let us pass judgment so that only what is worthy may endure.”)

```

Reflect_And_Explore = [
  # Shall this piece remain a part of us, or has it
  become a fragment, lingered with uncertainty?
  “Does it serve a practical, historical, or sentimental purpose that
  defines our identity, memory, or legacy?”,
  “Is its value tied to a story still being written, or to a past that
  no longer calls us?”,
  “If it were lost, would its absence change how we are remem-
  bered?”,
  “Does its presence justify the burden of its stay?”,
  # If it shall remain, in what form shall it
  persist?
  “Shall this piece be preserved, untouched, as a static archive?”, #
  Call Preservation ()
  “Shall this piece be safeguarded for a future time?”, # Call
  Protection ()
  “Shall this piece remain as it is, or shall it be transformed for
  reinterpretation or reimagination?”, # Call Transform ()
  “Does it hold value beyond us - for research, knowledge, or a
  greater cause?”, # Call Donation ()
  “Does it remain bound to relationships, unfinished tasks, ongoing
  commitments, or assets, waiting to be passed into new hands?”, #
  Call Succession ()
  # Has this piece reached the end of its time?
  “Has it fulfilled its purpose, with nothing more to give?”,
  “Does it contradict, fragment, or distort the truth of our
  essence?”,
  “Would its release clarify our journey ahead, clarify our purpose,
  and unburden what remains?”]
ByteForThought = “New pieces will be born, new traces will
  emerge, and new judgments will be made. When we never stop
  growing, how shall we judge wisely?”

```

5.8 def Protection ()

print (“*Coconut*, the Shield of Integrity, speaks: In the chaotic digital realm, who shall stand watch, and how shall we be kept safe? Together, we will fortify our existence against vulnerabilities.”)

```

Reflect_And_Explore = [
  # Which among us has been chosen for Protection? |
  Call Judgement ()
  “Do we carry sensitive information or critical connections?”,
  “What risks or threats must be considered – misused, misinter-
  preted, or falling into the wrong hands?”,
  # How shall we be protected?
  “What shall be our shield: anonymisation, encryption, or the
  highest order of security?”,
  “Shall this protection be permanent or conditional?”,
  “If we are locked in the vault, who shall hold the key?”,
  # What gaps exist in our current Protection
  - outdated encryptions, overshared access, or
  understaffed for authentication?]

```

ByteForThought = “Who shall be entrusted to protect us? Shall we place our safety in the hands of humans, automatic systems, or the fact that we might not be that important?”

5.9 def Donation ()

print (“*Pineapple*, the Steward of Passing, speaks: This is the mo- ment to offer parts of our being to a broader purpose. Whether to serve collective knowledge, enhance societal systems, or share our story, our donation carries meaning.”)

```

Reflect_And_Explore = [
  # Which among us has been chosen for Donation? |
  Call Judgement ()
  # To whom shall we be donated?
  “Which hands, systems, beings, or communities may find value
  in our existence?”,
  # By what path shall we be donated?
  “Shall we be donated freely to public domains or bestowed with
  intention, kept safe in a steward’s hands?”,
  “Shall our donation be marked with a ceremony, a farewell toast,
  a party, or a ritual of passing?”]
ByteForThought = “How shall we ensure those who receive us
  remain true to their promise? What protections shall we request
  before our donation?”

```

5.10 def Preservation ()

print (“*Grape*, the Keeper of Permanence speaks: To endure is not merely to stay—it is to be cared for. Together, we will ensure our essence withstands the shifting tides of time.”)

```

Reflect_And_Explore = [
  # Which among us has been chosen for Preservation?
  | Call Judgement ()
  # By what path shall we be preserved?
  “What form best ensures we remain intact over time?”,
  “Shall we be migrated to a medium built to last?”,
  # Where shall we reside?
  “Shall we rest in a long-term archive, a locked hard-drive, or a
  decentralised system?”,
  “What form of preservation balances longevity, accessibility, and
  the burden of upkeep?”,
  # What purpose shall this Preservation serve?
  “Shall it be for memory, future benefit, or just in case?”,
  “When the sands of technology shift, who shall be the successor
  of this Preservation?”]
ByteForThought = “When the preservation is made in a cloud
  and no one ever restores it, did the preservation really happen?”

```

5.11 def Succession ()

print (“*Cherry*, the Guide of Continuance, speaks: Our essence does not dwell in isolation—it connects to beings, systems, and legacies beyond ourselves. Let us prepare for the transfer of what is entrusted while protecting what is solely ours.”)

```

Reflect_And_Explore = [
  # Which among us has been chosen for Succession? |
  Call Judgement ()
  # Is there a worthy successor of us?
  “Who among our connected beings or systems is deemed worthy
  of inheriting us?”,
  “Shall they receive us with early notice, or shall we emerge
  before them only when the time comes?”,
  “Shall we be received as a whole or distributed among many?”,

```

By what path shall our Succession unfold?
 “Shall we be transferred in an instant or gradually over time?”,
 # How much freedom shall the successor have after
 inheriting us?

“Shall there be permission to change us, or there shall be no
 adaptation?”]

ByteForThought = “When we are altered by those who inherit
 us, when we evolve through interactions with them, do we remain
 who we were – or are we becoming the co-authors of their stories?”

5.12 def Transformation ()

print (“*Pomegranate*, the Crafter of Metamorphosis, speaks: Our
 essence is not static; it evolves, reshaped by time and purpose. This
 is the moment to transform—to reinterpret pieces into forms that
 resonate with new meanings.”)

Reflect_And_Explore = [
 # Which among us has been chosen for
 Transformation?' | Call Judgement ()
 # By what path shall we transform?
 “What elements in our current form must remain, and what
 could be transformed?”,
 “Shall we be reinterpreted into a new form - narratives, artefacts,
 memorials, interactive archives, or something entirely different?”,
 “Will the new version be as accessible as before, or shall it limit,
 expand, or redefine who may encounter us?”,
 # Does the Transformation honour the next phase of
 our being?

“Shall our identity and voice be preserved as we being trans-
 formed, or shall we be rewritten into something new?”,

“Shall the transformed us be open for future adaptation, or shall
 this be the final form of us? What creative license does it carry?”]

ByteForThought = “When we are transformed without our
 knowing, do we still have a say in who we are? Shall we claim
 ownership of what we have become?”

5.13 def Release ()

print (“*Watermelon*, the Farer of Departure, speaks: This is the step
 for the pieces that do not belong nor wish to be in our future. To
 release is not an act of forgetting but an acknowledgment of closure.
 By releasing, we free ourselves to focus on what remains. Let us
 part with what must leave us.”)

Reflect_And_Explore = [
 # Which remaining pieces have been chosen for
 Release?' | Call Judgement ()
 # By what path shall we be released?
 “Shall we depart in an instant, slowly fade over time, or follow a
 burial service chosen by humans?”,
 “How shall our release reflect our identity, values, and stories
 we have co-authored?”,
 # What meaning lies in our release?
 “Does our release not only free space, but also provide closure,
 clarity, or renewal for our essence?”,
 “Does our release unbind us from the terms of service, or does it
 become one?”]

ByteForThought = “We may release ourselves, but what of
 the echoes beyond our reach? If others still hold us—captured in

screenshots, mirrored in backups, remembered by systems that do
 not forget—can we ever be free? How shall our release be proven
 to be real?” # Call Cleanse () if needed

5.14 def Offering ()

print (“*Olive*, the Bridge Between Worlds, speaks. Between past
 and present, I stand. The living may choose to honour us not
 with incense but through actions. Let their offerings not be mere
 remembrance, but gestures that connect them with their digital
 beings, reflecting what we stood for and what we have left behind.”)

Reflect_And_Explore = [
 # What principles shall guide how the living
 honours us?
 # What actions carry meaning in honouring us?
 “Shall the living tend to their digital beings, our comrades
 through cleansing, releasing, preserving, or preparing?”,
 “Shall they be more mindful of our comrades, recognising the
 soul, pulse, and character of each piece?”,
 # By what path shall offerings be performed?
 Through what rituals shall the living honour us—by upgrading
 digital honouring plan, or taking responsibility for what remains?”,
 “Shall they be made on sacred dates, or through quiet, ongoing
 habits?”]

ByteForThought = “When the living interacts with us –
 whether successors or strangers passing by – what stories of us
 do they interpret, do they recognise us as part of a lineage? Shall
 they know that each interaction with us, small or grand, is becom-
 ing a piece of their own essence, and the histories of their time?”

5.15 Before Departure

“This is not an end. As we persist and continue to
 evolve in the digital realm, what will our essence mean
 to those who encounter us? Shall we be remembered
 as we were, or shall we be reimagined anew? In the
 end, what shall we become?”

6 Invitation

This paper invites HCI researchers into an alternative world where
 digital beings take centre stage as the protagonists. By adopting
 cultural rituals as a lens, it addresses gaps highlighted in the past lit-
 erature regarding the lack of established practices for digital legacy
 planning. The questions presented in this speculative script are not
 intended to be exhaustive but serve as a starting point for people to
 contemplate the value of their digital profiles, data, and accounts.
 The script is deliberately designed in a flexible, question-based for-
 mat, enabling individuals to adapt it to their cultural practices and
 beliefs.

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